



(From left) 1. Rahul Kanwal, News Director, *India Today* and *Aaj Tak*, and Executive Director of *Business Today*, with Professor Srikant Datar, Dean of Harvard Business School 2. Aabha Bakaya, Senior Editor and Anchor, *Business Today TV*; Rahul Kanwal; Piyush Goyal, Minister of Commerce and Industry, Consumer Affairs, Food and Distribution, and Textiles; Kalli Purie, Vice Chairperson, India Today Group; and Srikant Datar

**PROFESSOR SRIKANT DATAR**, Dean of Harvard Business School (HBS) tackles the burning questions on post-pandemic work, The Great Reset, globalisation and the big opportunity ahead for India. In a free-flowing conversation with Rahul Kanwal, News Director of *India Today* and *Aaj Tak*, and Executive Director of *Business Today* at BT's Master Class, Datar shares insights on navigating uncertainties in the post-pandemic era. Edited excerpts:

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**What are the big trends you've noticed in management practices, especially in the post-pandemic world?**

I started my term as Dean in the middle of the pandemic and an academic year. Each of those has challenges but what is incredible is the amount of opportunity it

creates. I spoke to nearly 1,000 individuals [and] went on a listening tour for four or five months. There were three things that emerged. One was the focus on digital data [and] work. At some level, the pandemic accelerated it by years. How should [a] business begin to think about its role in society was a second big thing that happened... And the third of course, is the major trend that occurred in terms of the future of work. As in all countries, some call it The Great Reset, while others call it The Great Resignation—how should we be thinking about the way in which we would engage individuals inside organisations.

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**How do you think leadership styles need to change post the pandemic?**

You can already see several trends. An important one is a focus on

ESG issues. You also see a much heavier focus on purpose. The idea is, why should someone work for a company—what is their broader purpose? Of course, we always want long-term profitability, because without that, there is no sustainable business. And I think from a leadership point of view, it has raised issues about resilience. How do you build resilient organisations that are able to contend with the uncertainty? How do you act speedily? It is leadership that is agile, and not just resourceful and adaptive.

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**One of the big issues that HR teams the world over are grappling with is trying to get the workforce back into office. What's your advice?**

Some of the data shows that on the one hand, individuals want flexibility, but on the other hand, it shows